

Primary Source Reading 2: The Paradox and the Promise of Recollection

Optima Academy Online | Philosophy & Ethics | High School Honors (9–12) From Plato's Meno, translated by Benjamin Jowett Read before Lesson 3b: The Paradox of Inquiry

Before you read: Socrates has just admitted that he, too, no longer knows what virtue is — but he proposes that he and Meno search for the answer together. Meno's response is not another definition. It is a challenge to the very idea of searching for something you don't already have. As you read, follow Socrates' surprising answer: a claim about the soul that, if true, changes what "learning" means.

Meno's Challenge

MENO: And how will you enquire, Socrates, into that which you do not know? What will you put forth as the subject of enquiry? And if you find what you want, how will you ever know that this is the thing which you did not know?

SOCRATES: I know, Meno, what you mean; but just see what a tiresome dispute you are introducing. You argue that a man cannot enquire either about that which he knows, or about that which he does not know; for if he knows, he has no need to enquire; and if not, he cannot, for he does not know the very subject about which he is to enquire.

MENO: Well, Socrates, and is not the argument sound?

SOCRATES: I think not. (80d–e)

A Glorious Truth

MENO: Why not?

SOCRATES: I will tell you why: I have heard from certain wise men and women who spoke of things divine that —

MENO: What did they say?

SOCRATES: They spoke of a glorious truth, as I conceive... Some of them were priests and priestesses, who had studied how they might be able to give a reason of their profession: there have been poets also, who spoke of these things by inspiration, like Pindar, and many others who were inspired. And they say — mark, now, and see whether their words are true — they say that the soul of man is immortal, and at one time has an end, which is termed dying, and at another time is born again, but is never destroyed... The soul, then, as being immortal, and having been born again many times, and having seen all things that exist, whether in this world or in the world below, has knowledge of them all; and it is no wonder that she should be able to call to remembrance all that she ever knew about virtue, and about everything; for

as all nature is akin, and the soul has learned all things, there is no difficulty in her eliciting — or as men say, learning — out of a single recollection all the rest, if a man is strenuous and does not faint; for all enquiry and all learning is but recollection. (81a–d)

Idleness or Inquiry

SOCRATES: And therefore we ought not to listen to this sophistical argument about the impossibility of enquiry: for it will make us idle, and is sweet only to the sluggard; but the other saying will make us active and inquisitive. In that confiding, I will gladly enquire with you into the nature of virtue.

MENO: Yes, Socrates; but what do you mean by saying that we do not learn, and that what we call learning is only a process of recollection? Can you teach me how this is?

SOCRATES: I told you, Meno, just now that you were a rogue, and now you ask whether I can teach you, when I am saying that there is no teaching, but only recollection; and thus you imagine that you will involve me in a contradiction.

MENO: Indeed, Socrates, I protest that I had no such intention. I only asked the question from habit; but if you can prove to me that what you say is true, I wish that you would.

SOCRATES: It will be no easy matter, but I will try to please you to the utmost of my power. Suppose that you call one of your numerous attendants, that I may demonstrate on him.

MENO: Certainly. Come hither, boy.

SOCRATES: He is Greek, and speaks Greek, does he not?

MENO: Yes, indeed; he was born in the house.

SOCRATES: Attend now to the questions which I ask him, and observe whether he learns of me or only remembers. (82a–b)

After you read: Socrates has made a serious claim — not a comforting slogan, but a real metaphysical proposal: that the soul has learned everything already, in a life before this one, and that questioning can bring the forgotten knowledge back. He is about to try to prove it, not with argument alone, but with a demonstration, using a boy who — as Socrates is careful to establish — has had no education in the subject he is about to be questioned on. The next lesson follows that demonstration step by step.